

Object Shows, Why I Like Them, Why Bot is My Favorite Character in any Object Show, and Why the Inanimate Insanity Finale Fell Flat for Me.

Some warnings before we get started - this is a pretty informal review. It's also a lot less structured than my usual reviews. Admittedly, this mostly so that I can talk about Object Shows without feeling really stupid. In this review, I'm gonna explain what an Object Show is and spoil a *lot* of [Inanimate Insanity](#) (II), seasons 1-3. It might get a bit annoying for people who've already watched the show, but it's important to me that people who don't intend on watching II (i.e., most of my friends), can follow this review and understand why I've thought about it so much.

Intro

These days, I watch a lot of children's TV. The two main shows I'm watching now are [Kamen Rider Gavv](#) and [Kamen Rider Zettz](#), both of which are Japanese Power-Rangers-style dramas aimed at small children and their moms. [Young Justice](#) is a Superhero cartoon for kids that I can't help but come back to every now and then. Even [The Amazing Digital Circus](#) (TADC), intended for [people in their 20s](#), has found itself with a substantially younger audience. Given the structural similarities and similar audiences, it shouldn't be too surprising that certain parts of TADC are [inspired](#) by [Battle for Dream Island](#) (BFDI), the very first Object Show.

Object Shows

To talk about Object Shows, I *need* to talk about BFDI, since every other Object Show draws direct inspiration from it. It's a game show where the characters are random items/objects, hence the name - any object, from a Pencil to a Black Hole, is fair game. Characters will die frequently, given how breakable some of their objects are - as such, each Object Show typically has a mechanism for bringing back dead characters. For BFDI, it's the recovery centers. For II, the host himself can bring them back. Each episode usually has the characters attempting to complete a challenge, with the viewers getting to vote on who they'd like to see "eliminated" from the competition. This is great for two reasons - first, the engagement helps boost the popularity of the series. Youtube's algorithm favors videos that get a lot of comments, and if you

can literally change the outcome of a show by leaving a comment, you'll probably do it. Second, if the creators haven't planned out their show in advance, they can use the viewers' response to inform the direction they should take and the relationships they should further develop.

For most shows, the lack of planning would degrade the quality of the production. And, yes - objectively speaking, the quality isn't really there. They'll drag out a joke that isn't particularly funny, draw parts of a face upside-down by accident, make characters do something gross just because they can, or repeat something they saw on another TV show that doesn't quite make sense in the context of their own show. For most TV shows, I'd probably call it quits and move onto something else. However, I can forgive these blunders - they're quite understandable when you realize that these shows were *made* by kids. Cary and Michael Huang were [only 12](#) when they created BFDI and Adam Katz [was 13](#) when he made II.

The charm of a bunch of kids figuring it out as they go along is what carries the early parts of these shows and makes them worth sticking with - in other words, you get to watch them grow up in real time. The animation will spike up dramatically in quality. Shot compositions will get more interesting. Character voices will deepen as their voice actor's own voices drop. If the creators suddenly get into music composition, astronomy, or 3D modeling, you'll be made *acutely* aware of it in the show itself.

Even cooler is how the showrunners will try and make sense of the mess left behind by their younger selves (and the audience) to form a coherent storyline. Nothing is forgotten or retconned, if they can help it. Leafy stealing Dream Island has consequences in later seasons of BFDI (BFDIA and TPOT), rippling out over a decade later. Amazingly, Inanimate Insanity somehow manages to incorporate its earlier artstyle inconsistencies into the storyline. People who've heard me talk about [Archie's Sonic the Hedgehog](#) run will be familiar with this idea - I absolutely love the more natural, emergent stories you can tell just by working with what you've got. It's the sort of thing you don't really get from more traditional production pipelines. Because there's no world where the first couple episodes of an animated TV show would accidentally draw half the character's mouths upside-down. There's no world where a couple of middle schoolers would produce a show with random commercial breaks advertising the concept of a Chair, run by a saleswoman named Bow. And there's absolutely no world where they'd let Bow violently blow up the host as part of the season 1 finale.

That freedom's a big part of why these shows are so enjoyable. Yes - they're made for children, but they don't need to adhere to traditional TV programming guidelines. This creative freedom is mostly used for unhinged jokes and artstyle changes, but sometimes they take it even further. If the producers of II wanna completely *pause* Season Two a couple episodes before the finale and run Season Three all the way through before actually finishing Season Two, they can just *do* that. And what's crazier is that they can actually make it *work*.

The part where I actually talk about Inanimate Insanity

Before we get *fully* into it, I need to spoil some reveals in Season Two of Inanimate Insanity.

First is that the host, Mephone 4, was created by Steve Cobs. Putting it lightly, Cobs wasn't a great parent. Even though Mephone 4 is fully sentient and has free will, he was created specifically to acquire more "shimmer" energy from these... egg-shaped aliens. He can use that energy to generate almost anything out of thin air. Whenever he failed or faltered, Cobs reacted strongly. This is best seen in the remains of the phones before 4. When he found what was left of those prior models, he ran away, deleted those memories, and started running his show.

Inanimate Insanity is about a lot of things - one of the big analogies running through the whole show connects the relationship between a parent and their child to the relationship between a god and their creation. Mephone 4's interactions with Cobs reflect this connection. Their dialogue often reads like an exchange between a neglectful father and their child, doing everything they can to get his approval. At the same time, Cobs literally built Mephone 4 and has complete control over his life and abilities. Even after Mephone 4 runs away, Cobs *allows* his show to run and only steps in when he figures out how best to take advantage of Mephone and his contestants in order to trick the egg-shaped aliens into coming back to Earth. Cobs' threats to un-make Mephone and replace him with someone newer teeter between abusive and existentially terrifying. Cobs is Mephone's god and he uses that power to behave like a bad parent.

If you met your god, what would you say to him? Maybe you'd ask him why he made you like this - why he made you with non-functioning limbs, why he made you so fragile, why he made you the gender you did, or why you feel sick all the time. Or maybe you'll ask him why he's put you through all of his so-called "tests". You might wanna ask why he made you in the first place if it seems like he hates you or why he seems so attached to a version of you that doesn't even exist.

Now, imagine this - you've actually met your god and it turns out he didn't really mean to make you. Imagine that he came up with you as a one-off joke and didn't really know what to do with you afterwards.

This is the second major reveal in Inanimate Insanity Season Two, after the hiatus. All of the contestants on II were spontaneously generated by Mephone 4, based on little drawings he made years prior. All of their memories, backstories, issues, and childhoods were all created on the spot so that he'd have people to participate in his reality show. And he didn't even intend to do it.

This reveal builds on the godhood analogy pretty well, using Mephone's role as the show's host. Even though he doesn't mean his contestants any harm and wants them to like him, he still has a disproportionate amount of control over their lives. There's the aforementioned terror of having a completely fabricated life/history. More directly, he controls who lives and dies since he *is* this show's revival mechanic. Additionally, the whole point of his show is that the contestants need to follow his instructions and play his games. If they don't listen to him, they're more likely to get eliminated. It isn't even one of his powers - this is just the effect an overbearing gameshow host has on its participants. Hell, if he feels like it, he can just *freeze* some of his contestants in time while he starts an entirely new Season with everyone else.

Season Three of Inanimate Insanity features some fan-favorite characters who didn't have enough time in Season Two, alongside some newcomers. Curiously, Bow, who *died* in Season One and returns in Season Two as a ghost, is alive here and seemingly participates as normal. This may seem strange, since Season Three isn't a prequel and I previously praised II's commitment to continuity. At first, this seems like a major retcon, but it's all by design.

One of the big twists in Season Three is that "Bow" isn't actually Bow and is, instead, a robotic recreation built by Test Tube and Fan, since neither of them could really cope with Bow's death.

And from there, everything about their arc just *works*. Their conversations with Test Tube about letting them be a different person from Bow are well-written and read like a queer kid trying to come out to their confused-yet-supportive parents. They chose a new name for themselves, Bot. Their journey of self-definition ties into several other characters' arcs about how they can't just let one-off events and traits define their entire beings. Bot's redesign, converting Bow's general shape into that of a robotic butterfly to symbolize growth and change,

is very elegant. Bot being a product of Test Tube's and Fan's inability to let go of Bow connects to Season Three being a product of Mephone 4's inability to let go of Inanimate Insanity and actually *end* Season Two. Bot somehow manages to connect all of these major threads, arcs, and metaphors without it feeling unearned or overbearing - other characters still get their fair share of screentime.

The fact that Bot isn't a Mephone creation is also quite clever - they can't be recovered through MeLife, which is why Test Tube takes extra care to make sure they don't die. They don't have Mephone's fake childhood memories either, so when Mephone brings in Springy, a seemingly major figure from every other contestant's childhood, Bot being unfamiliar with him foreshadows the post-hiatus Season Two reveal.

Bot also extends the godhood-parenthood analogy. Fan/Test Tube's relationship with Bot, Mephone's relationship with all of the contestants, and Cobs' relationship with Mephone all parallel each other. This extension says something about the way parental abuse can unintentionally carry across generations and, as seen in Bot, how you can put a stop to it. Acting like a cruel, uncaring god isn't your only option - you aren't *forced* to be an asshole, just because you have power over someone. When you listen and let your kids and creations define themselves, beautiful things can spring forth.

Bot just makes the *entire* show work, which is why they're my favorite character. Plus, I have a soft spot for sentient robots with an arc about finding purpose outside of the one their creators gave them.

Between that and Bot being completely disconnected from MeLife, I was hoping that they would play a big role in Season Two's finale. If Cobs did anything to Mephone 4's ability to revive contestants, Bot would be immune. There's also something very symbolically satisfying about Bot, whose "parents" eventually learned to let them be their own person, kicking the shit out of Cobs, the main "abusive parent" figure across the entire series.

However, Bot didn't get to do anything in the Season Finale. In fact, they don't show up until *after* Cobs is killed, staying offscreen the entire time. It's clearly a way to hide the main twist of Season Three, but it just muddles the whole "Season Two was paused to start Season Three" and makes the intended watch order of II more confusing. Season Three is written in a way that foreshadows Season Two's post-hiatus twist without completely giving the game away,

implying that you're supposed to stop in the middle of Season Two and watch Season Three. However, Season Two's finale hiding one of Season Three's twists implies that you're supposed to watch Season Three *after* Two's finale, which doesn't make any sense since Three is very coy about the origins of each contestant. It completely undermines my two favorite things about Inanimate Insanity - the completely deranged Season Two hiatus and Bot's entire character, which is why it fell flat for me.

On its own, the ending is fine. I'm glad Box turned into an actual character instead of a corpse dragged around for a recurring gag. The fact that the contestants don't want Mephone 4 around anymore, and the fact that he obliges, is quite nice, since I was (pessimistically) expecting them to play goody-goody with the person who caused all of their suffering. Those of you who've actually seen II probably expect some complaints about the final scene itself - the whole concert/dance party. It's okay. It's not my favorite - I understand *why* it's there, since the showrunners think music played a big role in Season Two. For me, there are only a couple of good tracks. [Karma Waits](#), which plays in the background of the first scene in the last episode, and [Taco's Tirade](#), which was my fifth favorite song of 2024. All of the other songs aren't great, which is why paying tribute to them feels somewhat hollow.

Conclusion

Inanimate Insanity is a very unique show. Watching the creators grow up alongside the show itself is already a novel experience, and the fact that they were able to leverage the earlier lower-quality material to help tell a story about parenthood, godhood, and escapism is something that makes it irreplaceable. However, their inability to commit fully to their most unhinged decision and underutilize my favorite character somewhat sours an otherwise decent ending. Maybe it's good, then, that the showrunners have disregarded their own show's message about letting things end and have started working on Season Four.

Addendum - Random Critique of The Amazing Digital Circus??

I didn't know how to fit this into the main review. I mentioned TADC at the start and I thought I could use that to make a cool transition into this section, and then somehow transition out and talk about Object Shows, but I couldn't quite make it work. Turns out that you can't just slap a TADC critique onto the beginning of my II review. Who knew!

To be clear - I really like TADC. Stylized 3D animation is tricky, especially for indie production teams, so I'm glad that they're leading the charge on that front. It's also pretty fast-paced - important plot-advancing stuff happens constantly and there's, overall, less "filler" than most Object Shows. However, I feel that this works against the show.

First, it seems like all of the major norm-breaking stuff only happened once Pomni joined the circus. It's as if none of the other characters had bothered looking slightly deeper over the *years* they spent trapped in the circus and, seemingly, only gained consciousness once the protagonist got trapped with them. This makes the world feel more hollow, since the characters don't actually do much beyond what you see in the show itself.

Second is that you don't really *feel* what normal life in the circus looks like for these characters. We've seen maybe one or two adventures go as intended under Caine's direction, which we're told is normal life from before Pomni showed up. I can imagine this well enough, but the fact that we haven't seen most of those adventures makes each characters' irritation with the status-quo and Caine slowly losing his shit feel less earned. A story about breaking a cycle could land *really* well if the viewer also feels like they're trapped in that cycle. Plus, it'd help justify Jax's "archetype" worldview, and make each character breaking free of those archetypes feel more impactful.

Third - I'm not really attached to most of these characters. You don't have very many meaningful scenes to work with each of them before a change of heart or before everything goes to shit. I like Zooble, but they really only get the "therapy" scene in Episode 3, the brief bar adventure in Untitled, and a couple of conversations with Gangle. Ragatha gets part of the bar scene, a conversation with King, and *maybe* the baseball adventure in untitled. It's why Jax taking up so many meaningful scenes feels irritating for people who don't really like him - there isn't very much screentime to go around.

All of this could be fixed with more episodic filler episodes - stuff where your beliefs are slightly challenged and the actual "plot" of the episode is just about the characters trying to make it through another one of Caine's adventures. It'd put Pomni through the stuff the other characters had to put up with over the years they've been trapped in the circus, it'd show us what the status-quo looks like, and it'd give you more opportunities to squeeze in meaningful character moments that get you attached without pushing the plot along too fast and bringing about the finale early. This is part of why I like fan comics where they explore more "ordinary"

adventures that aren't about clipping out of bounds or escaping the circus - they give me an idea of what these characters are like normally while showing off cute moments that make me truly fall in love with 'em. [Absolute Dream's comics](#) are worth checking out - there's one where Jax accidentally teaches Pomni how to use pocket dimensions, one about poison, one about downtime between adventures, and one about what it's like to die in a digital world.

BFDI and II have their fair share of filler episodes, thanks to the "figure it out as we go" approach, and this makes it pretty easy to get attached to each character, even before they do anything super groundbreaking. Inanimate Insanity's Taco genuinely feels like a more complete person than Kinger from TADC. If TADC were paced more like an Object Show, I feel like that'd fix my main problems with the series.